PWMS Bills API — User Guide

Read-only parliamentary bills register · API v1 · for approved partner applications

Before you start

Your PWMS administrator gives you:

- the base address, e.g. `https://pwms.example.gov.za`
- a **client ID** and **client secret**
- the **`bills:read`** scope

Keep the secret private. If it is exposed, ask for it to be rotated. The API is read-only: you cannot create or change bills. Interactive documentation: `/api/v1/docs`.

1. Get an access token

```
POST /api/v1/auth/token/
curl -s -X POST "$BASE/api/v1/auth/token/" \
  -H "Content-Type: application/json" \
  -d '{"client_id":"YOUR_ID","client_secret":"YOUR_SECRET"}'
```

The response contains `access_token`, `refresh_token`, `expires_in` (900 seconds) and `refresh_expires_in` (86400 seconds).

- **Access token:** 15 minutes. Send it as `Authorization: Bearer <token>` on every call.
- **Refresh token:** 24 hours, single use. Exchange it at `POST /api/v1/auth/token/refresh/` with `{"refresh_token":"…"}` to get a new pair.
- On `401`, refresh (or obtain a new pair), then retry once.

2. Endpoints

Method and path	What it returns
`GET /api/v1/bills/`	List and search bills
`GET /api/v1/bills/{public_id}/`	One bill by its UUID
`GET /api/v1/search/`	Combined search; use `resources=bills`
`GET /api/v1/me/`	Your client ID and scopes

Every request needs `Authorization: Bearer <access_token>`.

3. Filters

Parameter	Use
`search`	Case-insensitive substring across all searchable fields
`search_fields`	Comma-separated subset of the searchable fields (below)
`bill_type`	`section-74`, `section-75`, `section-76`, `section-77`
`house_of_origin`	`na` or `ncop`
`public_status`	Status slug or exact name, e.g. `introduced`
`responsible_committee`	Committee UUID, name, short name or slug
`ordering`	`-created_at` (default), `created_at`, `updated_at`, `bill_number`, `title`, `introduced_date`
`limit` / `offset`	Page size (default 20, max 100) / records to skip

Searchable fields: `bill_number`, `title`, `short_title`, `description`, `sponsor_name`, `responsible_committee`, `atc_reference`, `order_paper_reference`, `public_status`.

4. Example requests

```
# Latest 20 bills
curl -sG "$BASE/api/v1/bills/" \
  -H "Authorization: Bearer $TOKEN" \
  --data-urlencode "limit=20" --data-urlencode "offset=0"

# Section 76 bills under consideration, newest first
curl -sG "$BASE/api/v1/bills/" \
  -H "Authorization: Bearer $TOKEN" \
  --data-urlencode "bill_type=section-76" \
  --data-urlencode "public_status=Under Parliamentary
Consideration" \
  --data-urlencode "ordering=-introduced_date"

# Search titles for "appropriation"
curl -sG "$BASE/api/v1/bills/" \
  -H "Authorization: Bearer $TOKEN" \
  --data-urlencode "search=appropriation" \
  --data-urlencode "search_fields=title,short_title"

# One bill
curl -s "$BASE/api/v1/bills/PUBLIC_ID/" \
  -H "Authorization: Bearer $TOKEN"
```

Use `curl -G --data-urlencode` (or your library's query parameters) for names with spaces or punctuation.

5. Pages and fields

A list response is a page with `count`, `limit`, `offset`, `next`, `previous` and `results`. Follow `next` until it is `null`; the links keep your search and filters.

Each bill includes `public_id`, `bill_number`, `title`, `short_title`, `description`, `bill_type`, `house_of_origin`, `sponsor` / `sponsor_name`, `introduced_date`, `responsible_committee`, `atc_reference`, `order_paper_reference`, `bill_document_url`, `public_status`, `current_version`, `identifier`, `is_overdue`, `deadline`, `priority`, `created_at` and `updated_at`.

`public_status` is the citizen-facing status; `current_version` is the current version label. Dates are ISO 8601; empty values are `null` or an empty string.

6. Common responses

Status	Meaning and action
`200`	Success
`400`	Invalid parameter; correct the request
`401`	Missing/expired token; refresh or get a new pair
`403`	Key lacks `bills:read`; contact the administrator
`404`	No bill with that `public_id`
`429`	Rate limit; wait for `Retry-After`, then retry

7. Practical tips

- Refresh before the 15-minute access token expires; handle `401` once.
- Use the `public_id` from the response, not an internal ID.
- Request only the page size you need; 20–50 keeps responses fast.
- Each key has a requests-per-minute limit (60 by default; your registration may differ).
- The token endpoint is limited to 20 requests per minute per IP address.
- Contact the PWMS administrator if a bill is missing or you need another scope.